NEWS ON AIR: SPOTLIGHT

A Discussion on World Mental Health Day

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Meghana Bose (Anchor): This is Akashwani. In the program spotlight, now we bring you a discussion on World Mental Health Day. Various **initiatives** by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare. The participants are Dr. Rajesh Sagar, professor of psychiatry, AIIMS Delhi, and Meghana Bose, anchor.

World Mental Health Day is observed every year on October 10th to raise awareness about mental health and promote access to appropriate care and support. The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare **reaffirmed** its **commitment** to making mental health care **accessible**, **affordable**, inclusive, and people-centered. Among the key **initiatives** highlighted by the ministry is Tele MANAS, the National Tele Mental Health Program which provides free, **confidential**, and round-the-clock counseling through the toll-free helpline 14416.

The ministry is also taking forward Man Jagriti to help strengthen community awareness, encourage timely help-seeking, and address the **stigma** surrounding mental health. In addition, mental health services have been also **integrated** into more than 1.83 lakh Ayushman Arogya Mandirs. While the district mental health program has been **sanctioned** for 767 districts, to discuss these **initiatives** and the broader importance of mental health care in India, we are joined by Dr. Rajesh Sagar, professor of psychiatry at AIIMS New Delhi. Welcome to the program, sir.

Dr. Rajesh Sagar: Thank you.

Meghana Bose: World Mental Health Day is an opportunity to draw attention to mental health as an **essential** part of overall well-being. What are the major mental health challenges today and why is it important to address them through public healthcare?

Dr. Rajesh Sagar: Meghana, I think this is a very important question—what are the major challenges with regard to mental health and how to address them. One, we should know that in India too the burden is huge, and we know the **prevalence** figure is that one in 10, like one person out of 10, do have a mental illness as such. We see a whole lot of conditions like depression, anxiety, substance use disorder; even we have a major issue about suicide and severe mental illness. So the burden is huge. At the same time, we have a huge treatment gap. I think that is also very important to know—about 80 to 90% is the treatment gap what the survey has said.

So what it means is when we say the treatment gap, out of 100 people who are there, only 10 to 20% seek effective treatment, and the treatment is there for these people. We also need to know that it is not only an individual problem; it affects the whole family, educational **attainment**, and overall productivity as well because mental illness has a direct link with economics too. People are absent from work, productivity goes down, efficiency goes down, and economic loss occurs. So that's also important to understand the challenges about the treatment gap and the challenges about people having a lot of **misconceptions**. They go to faith healers, they go for different religious treatments, and they do not think it's a health issue. Public healthcare needs to address mental health as a **fundamental** component of health. The access also needs to be ensured.

Meghana Bose: The Ministry of Health and Family Welfare has been working to make mental health care more **accessible** through digital services, community awareness, and the expansion of healthcare facilities. The theme for World Mental Health Day 2026 is "Lived experiences heard, real voices, real change," emphasizing the importance of listening to people with mental health conditions. How can their experiences be better reflected in the way mental health care policies and services are designed and delivered?

Dr. Rajesh Sagar: First of all, I think this is a very important theme. What we have been focusing on till now is professional knowledge, scientific evidence, what is there in the textbook, and the guidelines and so on. I think what is also important is to look from the patient **perspective** and the family **perspective**. Their voices need to be heard.

They also need to be **meaningfully** engaged in some of the programs and policies. Till now it was thought that all the programs are made by experts and policymakers, but in recent times some efforts have been made to actively involve them so that some changes in the policies can come up. This theme becomes **crucial** and important. Even when we are designing these services, they need to be a part of it. Not only them, but the caregivers are also important. Even in research, the patient group and caregiver group can direct towards these things, including **rehabilitation** planning or the **evaluation** of mental health programs.

Meghana Bose: One of the government's key **initiatives** in this area is Tele MANAS, launched on October 10th, 2022. Through the toll-free number 14416, people can access free, **confidential** mental health counseling and support at any time. By October 2026, this helpline has received more than 47.75 lakh calls. Dr. Sagar, can you shed a light on the role of Tele MANAS in bridging the gap between people experiencing mental health difficulties and the professional support that they need, particularly in rural and underserved areas?

Dr. Rajesh Sagar: Yes, I think it has really been very important because many people had difficulty in accessing services. That was one of the major **obstacles**—that some services were not available within the **vicinity** of 100 kilometers or 500 km. Now with Tele MANAS teleconsultation, one can seek help very easily by just making a phone call to 14416. It is not just a phone call, but the second tier is where accessibility services will also be there depending on the problem. It has benefited many people who were otherwise **hesitant** to talk because there is privacy in this, so the **stigma** component is taken care of.

Meghana Bose: As you talked about **stigma**, despite growing awareness and the expansion of services, **stigma** remains a significant **barrier**. How can public service, educational institutions, the media, and community organizations work together to challenge these **misconceptions** and make seeking mental health support more socially acceptable?

Dr. Rajesh Sagar: This is very important because **stigma** is one of the major **stumbling** blocks. Because of **stigma**, people are not seeking help. **Stigma** and **discrimination** are very important aspects, and we all **stakeholders** need to work collectively to cut down on it. Man Jagriti is basically to address this, because Tele MANAS alone will not be enough unless we create awareness. We must respect **autonomy** and confidentiality so that people will be more confident to talk about their problems. They are **hesitant** because they think they will be labeled, **ridiculed**, and embarrassed.

Meghana Bose: Dr. Sagar, can you shed a light about what is being done to address mental health concerns among the youth of India, particularly in schools, colleges, and workplaces?

Dr. Rajesh Sagar: In metropolitan cities under CBSE, mental health is an important issue, and the need is recognized now. Schools and colleges are actively taking part. The UGC and the Ministry of Education have taken **initiatives**. Everyone is aware that mental health cannot be ignored. There is a program where school ambassadors promote health and early identification. We always believe school teachers are important gatekeepers; if any problem is there in a child, they can identify it much easier and inform parents early on. However, while metropolitan areas are covered, much more needs to be done in rural and remote schools.

Meghana Bose: Very rightly said, Dr. Sagar. As we conclude, World Mental Health Day reminds us that mental health deserves the same attention as physical health and that seeking help should never be a source of shame. What is the most important change that India needs to make to build a society where mental health is understood and discussed openly?

Dr. Rajesh Sagar: The way we take care of physical health, we must take care of emotional health. Our society needs to learn how to support people who have problems or distress and not make fun of them. We always say, "no health without mental health." Mental well-being is an **integral** component of health itself. We need to discuss it much more often so that we reduce the **stigma** and create awareness. Early identification and early **intervention** give a good outcome. It doesn't require any **sophisticated** investigation, and it is almost completely treatable. So we hope that a positive change will come in the future.

Meghana Bose: Dr. Sagar, thank you so much for joining us on Spotlight and helping us understand the importance of **accessible** mental health care, the role of government **initiatives**, and the need to build a society where people can seek support without fear or **stigma**.

Dr. Rajesh Sagar: Thank you. It was a pleasure talking to you.